

Chapter 33-2: Tears

The top floor had only one room, surrounded by wooden platforms on all sides. Some peach blossom petals had fallen on the platforms, their fragrance rich and intoxicating, reminiscent of the strange scent she had detected on people from the Hehuan Sect. Ning Fuyi's heart immediately tightened, and she flashed to a stop beside the door.

After listening carefully to the sounds inside, her body immediately stiffened in place, her hand on the door uncertain whether it should push forward.

From inside came the faint sounds of a woman's labored breathing, sounding extremely painful. The sounds fell on her ears like tens of thousands of ants crawling over her body. There were also sounds of something shattering, as if objects on a table had been knocked to the ground and broken.

Ning Fuyi's heart felt as if it had been thrown into the sky. Fury surged from nowhere, nearly burning away her rationality, and the long-absent murderous hostility reappeared in her mind.

But just as she clenched her fists, Bai Lin at her feet became restless. With a headbutt, the door burst open with a thunderous crash.

With the tremendous sound of the door hitting the wall, the woman sitting on the couch inside immediately froze. She was wearing the white silk dress Ning Fuyi had seen her in that day when she was drunk. One hand supported her on the couch, the other covered her heart. Her face was pale as death, but fresh blood stains remained at the corners of her mouth and on her clothes, shockingly red.

The two faced each other. Chu Qingqiu couldn't help herself - fresh blood flowed from the corner of her mouth again. Her beautiful brows knitted together as if she was very afraid of Ning Fuyi's arrival.

"Ning, Ning Fuyi..." she said in a hoarse voice, waving her hand to make her leave. But unexpectedly, her body went soft and she nearly slid down from the couch, unable to speak further.

Ning Fuyi hadn't expected to see such a scene upon opening the door. Though she wasn't unfamiliar with seeing Chu Qingqiu injured, in most cases she would be fine by the next day.

She had thought that someone as powerful as Chu Qingqiu could easily heal any wound.

But this time seemed different.

Bai Lin had already run in and was whimpering at Chu Qingqiu. Chu Qingqiu struggled to suppress the metallic sweetness in her throat and spoke again, her voice stern but weak: "Get out."

Ning Fuyi instinctively wanted to retreat, but then remembered her purpose for coming here and quickly said: "Be careful..."

Before she finished speaking, she caught sight of a colorful butterfly that had somehow appeared at the previously empty window. Her heart sank as she raised her hand to sweep it away with immortal power. However, the butterfly suddenly dodged her immortal power at an extremely strange speed, flying toward her like a sharp sword while simultaneously spraying large amounts of bewildering smoke that instantly filled the entire room.

"Hold your breath quickly!" Ning Fuyi called out urgently while also holding her own breath. She formed palm strikes with both hands, each rotating in a circle to block the strange butterfly. However, the moment the butterfly touched her immortal power, it rapidly split into dozens of butterflies that surrounded her like a net covering heaven and earth.

Witnessing this scene, Chu Qingqiu already knew who was responsible. Unfortunately, at this moment her heart felt like needles were stabbing it, her immortal meridians were in chaos, and she couldn't exert much power for the time being. She could only endure the pain and say: "Ning Fuyi, one leaf obscures the eye¹."

An illusion technique? Ning Fuyi immediately understood. She closed one eye, and the dozens of butterflies before her suddenly became blurred, with only one still glowing with strange light.

In the next instant, she opened both eyes and sent her immortal power straight through the butterfly's body. The butterfly immediately turned into light smoke and dispersed in mid-air.

Only the pattern on the butterfly's wings suddenly flashed, stinging her eyes.

Seeing that the butterfly was gone, Ning Fuyi relaxed slightly. She covered her nose and waved her hand, using wind to disperse the bewildering smoke in the room. The previously polluted air gradually returned to normal.

"Hehuan Sect," Chu Qingqiu said with furrowed brows. "How did you come to be here?"

"I overheard them. I came to secretly tell you, consider it repaying a favor." Seeing no further abnormalities, Ning Fuyi figured that the people from the Hehuan Sect, knowing they had been discovered, had already fled. So she turned to answer.

"Since you're unharmed, I'll leave now." Ning Fuyi didn't inquire about Chu Qingqiu's injuries but turned to leave. If she hurried, she could still secretly enter Shenyu tonight.

However, just as she turned around, she sensed something was wrong. Her previously clear mind suddenly became muddled, and the white gauze outside the door seemed to surge toward her like an overwhelming tide.

She quickly closed her eyes and stepped back, her hand hitting the lamp stand by the door. The burning lamp immediately fell to the ground, but the candle burned even more fiercely, illuminating the room in flickering light and shadow.

"Ning Fuyi?" Chu Qingqiu immediately realized something was wrong. She suppressed the urge to vomit blood, waved her finger lightly, and the door suddenly slammed shut.

However, the young woman paid her no attention, standing with her back to her. The flowing firelight only illuminated her earlobe.

"Ning Fuyi!" Chu Qingqiu gritted her teeth and stood up, walking barefoot toward her. But before she could touch Ning Fuyi, her own wrist was suddenly grasped.

That palm was as hot as the lamp fire.

Ning Fuyi slowly turned around, her hair blown aside by the wind, revealing her beautiful brows and eyes. However, she wasn't smiling at this moment, so she looked several degrees more sinister.

Through the appearance of the young woman before her, Chu Qingqiu seemed to see once again that terrifying Heaven-Slaying Demon from the past.

"Bai Lin, go call for help," Chu Qingqiu said calmly, maintaining eye contact with Ning Fuyi.

Bai Lin also understood the gravity of the situation. Upon hearing this, it moved its paws and was about to leap out the window, but was stopped by Chu Qingqiu's sharp command.

"No, come back." Chu Qingqiu gripped the corner of her clothes tightly.

No one could be allowed to see Ning Fuyi in this demon-possessed state, and she knew how difficult it was to break the spells of the Hehuan Sect.

Bai Lin whimpered once.

"You also go out and guard outside. Don't let anyone in." Chu Qingqiu said. Although Bai Lin didn't understand, it was very obedient and disappeared outside the window in the blink of an eye, leaving only her and Ning Fuyi alone in the room.

Ning Fuyi's vision was still alternating between light and dark, and a special sensation was surging through her body, spreading to every part of her, making her feel irritated and feverish.

But what she held in her palm felt like ice, making her urgently want to embrace it to dispel the heat from her body.

The young woman's hand suddenly lifted, and Chu Qingqiu was pulled by her in a circle, her body hitting the table. She winced in pain, and combined with her old injuries recurring and her body being weak, she nearly blacked out and fainted.

The young woman before her had already lost her rationality. She suddenly grabbed her arm and stepped forward, instantly closing the distance between them. The peach blossom fragrance from the young woman's body rushed into her nostrils, causing Chu Qingqiu's heart to contract violently as she turned her head to avoid it.

Only through extremely strong willpower did she manage to clear her vision again.

"White Bone?!" Chu Qingqiu suddenly roared in a low voice. The white jade flute suddenly leaped up from the couch, transformed into a white jade staff, and abruptly crossed over Chu Qingqiu to drag Ning Fuyi backward by the waist. Her back hit the wall hard.

Ning Fuyi let out a muffled groan. Her disheveled hair stuck to her sweat-covered face, her high nose bridge breathing rapidly. Her already red lips became even more blood-colored, and her skin was ghostly pale.

She tilted her head back against the wall, her right hand gripping White Bone trying to push it away, while her left hand clawed deep into the wall cracks, leaving bloody scratches.

It was as if ten thousand streams of fire were crashing within her body, seeking an outlet for release, while countless illusions flashed before her eyes.

Chu Qingqiu supported herself on the table edge, barely standing. She watched Ning Fuyi in this state through gritted teeth, her hands almost digging into the stone table.

Seeing the bloodstains on the wall increasing, Chu Qingqiu instead became calm. She stood in place, quietly watching Ning Fuyi, her peach blossom eyes slowly drooping.

Then she said softly: "White Bone."

The white jade staff immediately released all its force and fell to the ground with a clang.

In the next instant, the black figure fell before her like an arrow. Chu Qingqiu was pushed onto the table by her sudden force. The thin white dress couldn't block the coldness of the stone table, and the chill immediately penetrated her skin, traveling toward her heart.

But this coldness was quickly dispelled. The young woman's eyes were full of mad fire, her slender arms like furnaces as they wrapped around her waist, tightly confining her in their embrace.

The scent of peach blossoms grew closer and closer. Chu Qingqiu forcefully closed her eyes, unwilling to look into Ning Fuyi's eyes.

She could easily stop her.

But she didn't want to move.

"What are you hiding from?" Ning Fuyi suddenly spoke, her voice carrying a strange, deep quality that didn't match her appearance. Though she had lost her rationality, she could still feel the strange palpitations in her heart. So she extended her hand and slowly touched the face of the woman before her.

She could discern how beautiful she was - her long hair spilling across the table like spread ink, her eyes like peach blossoms after rain, mixed with resentment and defiance, blood still hanging at the corners of her mouth, her neck like smooth jade cream stained with a thin layer of sweat.

That face was as smooth as ice and snow. When she touched her chin, her hand became wet with moisture.

"Are you crying?" Ning Fuyi asked in a daze.

1. **One leaf obscures the eye (一叶障目)** - A Chinese idiom meaning to be deceived by superficial appearances; here referring to an illusion technique that creates false images
2. **White Bone (白骨)** - The name of Chu Qingqiu's magical flute weapon, which can transform into different forms